

Ashgrove PD — Det. L. Dawson — personal notes, not case file

reread: the morning after

Case Notebook

(written as Lilly's own notebook — reread over coffee before she leaves the house)

Ashgrove, Oregon. Still counting this job in days and I already reach for the wrong drawer for my own service weapon. Reading back over the Loman file before I head in — wanted it straight in my head before this morning gets away from me.

The Loman file

Frank Loman. Local fisherman. Reported missing my first or second day on the job — because apparently new detectives get handed the file nobody else wants first.

His car was on the lake road, about five clicks out of town. Found at the scene:

- Scratches on the wheel and the dash. Somebody was in that car who didn't want to be.
- Two sets of prints leaving the car toward the water — one in boots, one bare. They just stop at the waterline.
- A cassette tape in the mud, like it fell out of somebody's hand and got left there.
- The car radio putting out metallic static and a voice underneath it, badly distorted.

Doyle came out with me. We followed the prints to the lake. Heavy fog rolled in that evening, and there was a sound coming from across the water — metallic, almost rhythmic. Could be the old tower out that way. Nobody's confirmed that. Doyle heard it too, for what that's worth, and he doesn't strike me as a man who invents things to spare a rookie detective's nerves.

At some point, listening to that static, I would swear the radio said my name. I'm not writing that up officially. I'm writing it here so I don't talk myself into having imagined it.

Back at the station, Whitley wanted this filed small and quiet. "Not turning a missing fisherman into a circus" — his words. He's not wrong that Ashgrove doesn't want headlines. I just don't love how fast he wanted the drawer closed on a man who still hasn't been found.

Status: shelved. Frank Loman: still missing. Case: not closed, whatever the file says.

People (so I stop calling everyone "hey, you")

Chief Whitley. My boss. Mid-50s, comfortable in the job, wants Ashgrove boring and wants it boring on his schedule. Handed me Loman, then wanted it put away fast. Not an enemy exactly — just not on my side of this one.

Sgt. Tom Doyle. The other detective here, also floor sergeant. Married, a couple of kids. Quiet, doesn't fill silence for me and doesn't perform for an audience either — which, after New Jersey, is almost a relief. He heard the same sound I did out at the lake and didn't try to talk himself out of it. I trust his eyes more than most people's theories.

Nancy. Runs the precinct front office, and half the town's gossip through it. Warm to me, the new face. Knows who's related to whom and who said what to whom at the counter. Good person to ask when I need the human map of this place instead of the official one.

Abigail Carr. Local radio host, KCRK 102.3. I don't really know her yet — we've only spoken by phone, last night, when she called asking specifically for me. Said the station recorded something strange, timed almost exactly to when Frank disappeared. She sounded rattled, not performing. That's the call I still need to return.

Frank Loman. The man I'm actually supposed to be finding, and the one person in this file I haven't met — because he isn't here to meet. Local fisherman. That's still almost everything I know about him as a person, and it bothers me that it is.

Where this sits this morning

That's where last night left off: Abigail's call, unanswered, about a recording made at the exact hour Frank went missing.

Whitley thinks this is closed. I don't.

Still don't know:

- Where Frank actually is.
- What's on Abigail's recording.
- What that sound across the water actually was.
- Whose bare feet those were at the lake.
- What's actually on that cassette from the mud.

First thing today: call Abigail back.